

The Psychodynamic Approach to Coaching

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INTRODUCTION

For more than 100 years psychodynamic thinking has been a highly influential body of ideas regarding the workings of the human mind. This chapter describes the distinctive way in which these ideas can inform the activity of coaching, in particular showing how it provides a method for working with the unconscious, as well as the conscious, factors underlying human behaviour.

The term psychodynamic refers to a broad lineage of models that focus on the role of unconscious processes in human behaviour, and more specifically, on the dynamic relationship between different parts of the mind. Since Freud's (1922) first description of psychoanalysis there have been many developments, some of them building on Freud's ideas and his emphasis on instinctual drives, and others providing quite different formulations. Jung (1956) broke away to develop 'analytical psychology' in which prominence is given to the Self and the role of archetypes; Klein (1988) shifted the focus to the role of fantasy in the earliest stages of a child's development; Winnicott (1971) and many other object relations theorists (Greenberg & Mitchell, 1983) stressed the importance of the relationship between mother and baby in the shaping of mental life; and Bowlby (1988), for a long time disowned by much of the psychoanalytic community, researched the role of the caregiver in enabling the baby to form a safe attachment, and his empirical approach sparked a rich vein of research into attachment theory

(Goldberg, Muir, & Kerr, 1995). These are just some of the leading contributors to a constantly evolving field, which in some areas is now being validated by neuroscientific research into the role of non-conscious processes in emotional development (e.g. Solms, 1996; Schore, 2003).

This chapter provides an outline of how the psychodynamic approach can be used within a coaching context. It offers a perspective on coaching that emphasizes the role of the unconscious and past experience in shaping present ways of relating, whether to oneself or to others. By providing a safe relationship for exploring, naming and integrating difficult feelings, thoughts and memories, the coach enables the coachee to approach new challenges with a greater sense of clarity and authenticity. Following this introduction, I describe the goals and tasks of this tradition with some examples of its application to coaching. Then I illustrate some of the key phenomena on which the psychodynamic approach focuses on, such as holding, defence mechanisms, transference and counter-transference, and their relevance to coaching. Then I compare the psychodynamic approach to other approaches, followed by a discussion of its application in a number of different coaching contexts. Finally, I provide a summary of the strengths and limitations of this approach.

THE RELATIONAL REGULATION OF EMOTIONS

A contemporary psychodynamic perspective views the regulation of emotions (rather than instincts) as lying at the heart of much of human behaviour. As a result of previous relationships, particularly those with our parents or earliest caregivers, we develop distinctive but unconscious strategies for regulating our emotions and for building up a sense of self-identity. These early emotional habits tend to persist into adulthood because they become part of the developing brain's neuronal structure and brain chemistry (Gerhardt, 2004). These unconscious strategies are the engine of what Freud first described as 'the dynamic unconscious', an out-of-awareness part of the mind that shapes how we relate to ourselves and to others.

Defence mechanisms, such as repression, denial and projection, are specific examples of unconscious patterns of emotional regulation that operate to avoid or minimize emotions that are currently experienced as too difficult to tolerate. For example, a coachee might seem to persistently dismiss the importance of his/her feelings, a strategy of denial shaped by early experiences of rejection, which are now limiting the coachee's ability to form collaborative and mutually productive relationships in adulthood. The goal of the coach is essentially to expand the coachee's capacity for emotional regulation, that is, to enable the coachee, through the trust and containment of the relationship with the coach, to revisit difficult emotional territory in a way that is contained, so that the need for defensive strategies is reduced, and in which thinking rather than reacting can take place. By creating a space in which feelings can be experienced and labelled in language, they become phenomena that can be looked at and understood. Such a reworking of inner emotional territory, from disconnected sensations of emotional distress

that have to be instantly defended against, to meaningfully connected patterns of experience, is transformative because what was once unconscious has been brought into awareness.

The coach comes to know about the coachee's unconscious emotional patterns in a number of ways. These include understanding how the coachee enacts implicit emotional habits in current relationships, including that with the coach, i.e. the transference, and by noticing and making sense of the feelings and sensations evoked in the coach by the coachee, i.e. the counter-transference. The coachee's past experience is also viewed as a valuable source of information, since it is these experiences that provide the earliest patterning of unconscious processes.

One of the great challenges in working with the unconscious is 'resistance', the denial of observations or links made by the coach that are intended to increase the coachee's awareness. While it is necessary for the coach to work at the border of what the coachee is ready to hear and experience, the coach must constantly notice any signs of resistance and modulate the interaction to maintain a safe 'holding environment'. In the next section we look more closely at how the coach creates and sustains, through relational attunement, a holding environment that loosens resistance, enables the coachee to tolerate difficult and buried emotions, and so develop new areas of awareness and insight.

DISTINCTIVE FEATURES OF THE PSYCHODYNAMIC APPROACH

In highlighting the features that are most distinctive to the psychodynamic approach, it is useful to set them in the context of a more generic coaching process. I would suggest that all coaching uses some version of the following process: Contracting, Assessing, Developing, Implementing, Reviewing, with these stages used fluidly and cyclically, and describing the iterative process that occurs within coaching sessions, as well as providing a macro picture of the overall course of a piece of coaching. The psychodynamic approach operates within this broad, generic process: Contracting to agree the scope, boundaries and purpose of the work, both with the coachee and with any sponsors; Assessing to gather useful information; Developing to move the coachee on in some way; Implementing to translate new learning into new behaviours; and Reviewing to check for progress and ongoing realignment of the approach. With awareness that the work takes place within this generic coaching frame, I will highlight key features of the psychodynamic approach.

Creating a holding environment

The first task in coaching is to set up a way of working with coachees that can be described as a 'holding environment' (Winnicott, 1965); a physical, and perhaps more significantly, a psychological space in which coachees feel safe enough to be open with their thoughts and feelings, to be able to share their anxieties, frustrations, aspirations and deepest hopes. For example

when a senior manager was referred to me I was told that he had already met a number of coaches, but there was something about the formality of those initial meetings that had put him off. I guessed that his perception of formality had somehow triggered a sense of 'not being safe'; it had failed to support the psychological experience of a holding environment.

On meeting him I was struck by his formality, a rigid quality that made me feel as if I needed to sit up straight and to be at my most professional. However, rather than responding to this apparent pressure, I read it as telling me about one of his established strategies (or defences) for dealing with anxiety. Although I knew that this initial meeting would need to address the formal aspects of a coaching contract, I realized an experience of 'holding' for him needed to come out of my showing that I could contain his anxiety, and my own, and by my not mimicking his defensive strategy. I commented to him in a warm, gentle, mildly playful way, 'I wonder how we can make this an enjoyable meeting for us both?' His response was to smile, to relax a little, and to say how appealing it would be to have a space to slow down in his frenetic working day. My response, coming out of an intention to contain anxiety, without addressing it too directly at this early stage, had enabled the work to begin. Through this and other responses I sought to foster an atmosphere of neutrality and curiosity, a slower, reflective space in which inquiry, wondering and uncertainty is valued as highly as clarity, focus and decision making. Holding, then, in the psychodynamic sense, is concerned with attending to the non-verbal as well as the verbal elements of coach-coachee interaction, and in particular seeking to identify and respond usefully to the emotional agenda that might be underpinning the coachee's behaviour.

Defence mechanisms

Defence mechanisms, self-protective psychological strategies for dealing with distressing feelings, develop unconsciously in childhood, and later in situations where we perceive that others will not adequately regulate our emotions, or where our emotions will be perceived as socially unacceptable. For example coachees in organizations often use intellectualization as a way of dealing with upsetting personnel issues, projection as a way of blaming another department for organizational failings, and displacement as a way of keeping busy with unimportant details rather than tackling more important but anxiety provoking issues. Sometimes these defences are useful, such as when a doctor puts aside personal feelings of distress in order to deal with the practical issue of providing medical care. However, defences can often become a kind of strait-jacket for the coachee's identity. For example a coachee who idealizes others may be defending against negative feelings towards others, but fears that if these feelings are expressed then others may reject the coachee.

In coaching the goal is not so much to name specific defence mechanisms but to recognize when the coachee is enacting an unconscious strategy of emotional regulation; they are a clue that the coachee is in psychological territory that feels problematic or overwhelming. In time, with sufficient holding and with the development of a working alliance underpinned by trust

and rapport, the coach is likely to gain some understanding of the underlying emotional agenda, and so gradually move towards exploring the nature of these feelings with the coachee, their origins, their development, and their impact on current behaviour and performance.

Transference

One of the primary tools for gaining access to the coachee's implicit and potentially limiting interpersonal strategies is through the dynamics of transference and counter-transference. Transference refers to the implicit assumptions that we make about others based on our past experiences. If a coachee has experienced frowns from a routinely disapproving parent, he/she may attribute to a frowning coach disapproval that was actually an expression of confusion. If a coachee has experienced a parents' preoccupation with time as somewhat rejecting, then the coachee may experience the coaches' strict management of session times as rejecting rather than appropriately bounded. Transference can refer to any piece of unconscious learning that is applied to a new context, but its impact is most tangible when the transference occurs in relation to the coach, for example with the coachee unconsciously behaving towards the coach as if he/she is the coachee's boss or colleague or parent. Understanding the transference is usually linked to a related concept, that of counter-transference.

Counter-transference

Counter-transference refers to the feelings, bodily sensations, thoughts and behaviours that can be unconsciously evoked in the coach by the coachee. By silently examining these experiences the coach can gain insight into the unconscious concerns of the coachee. For example a coach, discussing in supervision a piece of work she was producing with a Managing Director (MD), reported that she felt useless and ineffective, and that she felt too inexperienced to continue with the work. As the supervision progressed she realized that what she was feeling was not really about her. As an experienced coach she felt confident in her ability, and she had previously worked with several MDs. She realized that the feelings evoked in her were directly linked to the MD's own unacknowledged sense of hopelessness about transforming the organization. Counter-transference experiences of this kind provide the coach with an embodied knowledge of the coachee's unexpressed feelings. This apparently mysterious transmission of unconscious feelings is understood in terms of a further mechanism, projective identification.

Projective identification, a concept originally introduced by Klein, is a process where the unconscious emotional experience of one person can be communicated to the unconscious of another. This occurs through subtle nuances of behaviour, such as facial expressions and modulations in the pace, tone and rhythm of the voice that are processed rapidly, non-consciously, and non-verbally in parts of the human brain that are also linked to our perception of bodily sensations (Schoore, 2003). By tuning into bodily feelings and sensations, the coach

can experience the coachee's non-conscious signals and so come to learn something about the coachee's disowned emotional state.

Thinking and the good enough coach

Working with counter-transference and projective identification is one of the most challenging aspects of the psychodynamic approach, because disowned feelings of the coachee are unconsciously projected into the coach, and containing these feelings often challenges to the limit the coach's own capacity for emotional regulation. In the example above, the coach's sense of capability had been temporarily disabled by the MD's projection into her of feelings of hopelessness. The coach had lost her capacity to think, and in this state she could not be of use to her coachee. Other coaches, on the receiving end of such projections, may find themselves resorting to neat, intellectual formulations, or providing coachees with practical materials to work on. These responses are defensive manoeuvres by the coach, and their impact on the coachee is usually to reinforce psychological defences.

In my experience, if we are vigilant to them, such disruptions to the coach's thinking are not uncommon (Bion, 1962). The goal for the coach, and I think coaching supervision can be invaluable here, is to find a way to reinstate the capacity to think. The coach needs to operate with a dual mode of attention, to attend to his/her own self-regulatory functioning and at the same time participate fully with the coachee in mutual exploration. The 'good enough coach' – an adaptation of Winnicott's phrase, the 'good-enough mother' – is not someone who always gets this right – rather it is a coach who manages to return him/herself to a state of regulation, having temporarily been overwhelmed. It is probable that the coachee, at an unconscious level, perceives this two-stage process, the rupture in the holding environment, and then the coach's return to a thinking state, and so gains an implicit, experiential knowledge that such feelings can be contained. Working at this level is undoubtedly demanding on the coach, but it lays the ground for a fundamental shift in the coachee's capacity to think about feelings, and clears the way for making more explicit links, such as those between past experiences and their impact on the present.

Making links

Much of the discussion thus far has emphasized the ways in which the coach can pay attention to the non-verbal aspects of the coach-coachee relationship and through such attentiveness create the underpinning conditions for the exploration and potential integration of the coachee's full range of emotional experiencing. However, also central to such integration is the naming of experiences – memories, thoughts, feelings, aspirations – and making links between different aspects of experience such that they are perceived and expressed as part of a more coherent sense of identity and personal narrative. One of the most powerful links that the psychodynamic approach seeks to make is between past and present. In order to do this the coach needs to elicit

a detailed biographical history from the coachee, which includes information about the coachee's relationships with parents and other significant people in his/her life. By understanding the nature of the coachee's formative relationships the coach is looking for clues about the kinds of unconscious strategies that the coachee has developed in the past, and which may still be operating in the present.

For example, a coachee feeling unconsciously angry and defiant with his father, who was constantly distracted and distant when the coachee was growing up, had a reputation for being difficult and abrasive with his colleagues, and his career was stalling as a consequence. After working with this man for some time I suggested to him that his difficulties with current colleagues was, in part, an unconscious rerun of his unresolved frustration with his father's lack of attention for him (a transference interpretation). Over several sessions, as we worked through this idea, he was increasingly able to acknowledge its relevance for him. By recognizing the unconscious agenda driving his behaviour he was able to look at his current relationships more objectively, and to discern ways in which he could influence and collaborate with his boss and colleagues more effectively.

Creative living

From the psychodynamic perspective coachees enter coaching with a sense of self that has, to a large extent, been shaped by their experiences and interactions, from earliest childhood through to the present. In areas where a person has experienced attunement and responsiveness from parents and other caregivers, then their capacity to make sense of their array of experiences can be managed and integrated, and their internal sense of security provides the basis for play, vitality and creative living. However, in areas where a person has experienced others as being unable to tolerate their feelings or behaviour, then defensive psychological strategies come into operation, and, persisting through time, these can limit a person's capacity for self-realization. In coaching, by creating a space in which disowned feelings can be tolerated, named and thought about, coachees are able to develop a more integrated sense of self, and so approach their work, and their lives, with an expanded capacity for creative living (Winnicott, 1971).

COMPARISON TO OTHER TRADITIONS

In comparing the psychodynamic approach to other theoretical traditions it is important to emphasize that in practice coaching is often used in an integrative way. Coaches, in contrast to counsellors or psychotherapists, do not typically label their style of coaching in terms of a theoretical tradition, but rather in terms of the contexts in which they offer their services. Coaching, through its evolution, is a more eclectic discipline, drawing on multiple models and techniques. Consequently, the coach whose approach is underpinned by psychodynamic thinking may also use ideas from transactional analysis, Gestalt, cognitive, solution-focused,

and any of the other major schools of thought. Having said that, it is useful to recognize key differences between approaches so that the coach can make conscious judgements about why one approach is being chosen over another.

The psychodynamic approach places a coachee's unconscious agenda at the centre of the challenge of enabling change. Many other traditions do share an interest in the unconscious, in some cases because their main proponents were themselves trained and influenced by psychodynamic thinking, such as in transactional analysis, Gestalt, and the transpersonal approach. Indeed, the emphasis in psychodynamic thinking on the intra-psychic domain, the internal and potentially conflictive relationship between different parts of the coachee's mind is echoed in transactional analysis as the ego states of Parent, Adult and Child, in Gestalt with such ideas as the 'top dog' and 'underdog' and in transpersonal work as sub-personalities (Rowan, 1991).

In practice, coaches readily borrow ideas from neighbouring traditions, so a coach working psychodynamically might encourage a coachee to name a part of themselves that is self-critical, which would fit with the transpersonal approach; or the coach might describe that part as a critical superego, which is more consistent with psychodynamic language. Having said all of this, it is the psychodynamic approach that is most consistently focused on unconscious emotional issues as the primary blocks to psychological development. The coach working psychodynamically, perhaps more than in other traditions, will develop quite detailed working hypotheses about the way different parts of the coachee's mind interact and the role that past experience has played in this development. Furthermore, particular emphasis will be given to making sense of the transference-counter-transference dynamics, although in contrast to the more spontaneous approach in Gestalt, the coach will take time to make sense of counter-transference feelings before making any explicit comment to the coachee.

The psychodynamic approach, used in isolation, could be contrasted most with the solution-focused approach and to some extent the positive psychology approach, where the focus is not on problems or underlying unconscious issues but on identifying what has already worked in the past, building upon strengths and finding practical solutions towards realizing goals. However, in my view the psychodynamic approach is most useful when it is allied in a more integrative way with these approaches that emphasize strengths and possibility. The cognitive behavioural approach can also be contrasted to the psychodynamic, in that although it does look at the links between emotions and beliefs and their impact on behaviour, it focuses primarily on what is in conscious awareness.

THE PSYCHODYNAMIC APPROACH IN CONTEXT

In this section I look at the psychodynamic approach in relation to four types of coaching: skills and performance coaching; developmental coaching; executive and leadership coaching; and team coaching.

Skills and performance coaching

Viewed as a method for optimizing performance in organizations, skills and performance coaching has become an established management development intervention. On the face of it the psychodynamic approach does not appear to be the most obvious fit in a context where the emphasis is on fulfilling certain behavioural competency standards. However, in many situations behavioural change cannot be achieved without understanding the underlying issues blocking change.

I introduced the concept of ACE patterns (Lee, 2003), integrated patterns of Actions, Cognitions and Emotions, to make explicit the link between unconscious emotional issues and their impact on behaviour. For example a junior manager who had not managed to improve her presentation skills, despite being sent on various skills development workshops, received a single session of coaching with me. She described how she would freeze when in front of an audience. I asked her to describe this experience of freezing (the Action) in detail, and then to look back through her history for times when she might have first had this experience. She reported that she would freeze like this when seeing her father's blank face as she sought his permission to do something, and went on to describe her deep fear (Emotion) of his disapproval. The link that we made was that she was unconsciously projecting her father's disapproval onto the blank faces of the audience when she made a presentation, and consequently froze with fear. By recognizing this link she could begin to approach presentations less dogged by her unconscious fear of her father's disapproval. This example illustrates that improving performance often requires coachees to increase their awareness of unconscious emotional blocks, and the psychodynamic approach provides an elegant method for making links and raising the coachee's self-awareness.

Developmental coaching

Development coaching is concerned with the development of the individual as a whole. While other types of coaching, such as performance or career coaching, are more focused on enabling the coach to develop in a specific area, development coaching has a broad remit encompassing a coachee's personal life as well as his/her work life. Thus development coaching might explore such areas as overarching purpose, underpinning values, signature talents and strengths, key obstacles, career ambitions, and personal and work relationships. The breadth of the approach means that developmental coaching is likely to draw on a range of theoretical traditions, including that of psychodynamic thinking.

One of the central goals of both developmental coaching and the psychodynamic approach to coaching is to increase awareness, since awareness of self and others is viewed as the foundation for making choices that are consistent with the purpose, values, ambitions and strengths of the coachee. The psychodynamic approach can be particularly useful in this context, because many people find that as life goes on they have gradually lost sight of their core passions and convictions; life has become a series of compromises, diluted ambitions, disillusioned hopes,

opportunities avoided due to fear. For example I worked with a senior manager in the pharmaceutical industry whose passion for healing, his core motivation for entering the industry, had been forgotten amid the daily challenge of meeting revenue and profit targets and managing a large sales force. Through an exploration of stories of people he found most inspiring he recalled how much he had enjoyed working in a health centre as a student. He also recalled that his father, a self-made businessman, had disapproved of his altruistic, 'softer' side, and had strongly directed him towards a business career. He realized that his desire for his father's approval had unconsciously influenced his choices over many years. This psychodynamic awareness opened up a much wider exploration of his choices, less constrained by his unconscious desire to please his father.

Although developmental coaching, like psychodynamic coaching, is more focused on raising awareness than on achieving specific shifts in behaviour, an increase in awareness typically leads to a shift in how a coachee thinks and feels, and these deeper shifts are often the key elements that underpin a more enduring shift in behaviour.

Executive and leadership coaching

In executive and leadership coaching, we are usually working with a population of managers who have already achieved a good deal of success in their careers, but whose future development requires them to shift perspective; for example, to augment their technical competence with a more strategic view, or to temper their driving leadership style with greater political awareness and effective influence skills. I have suggested (Lee, 2003) that if managers are to be successful leaders then they need to become authentic, in the sense that they consciously balance their personal needs and convictions with the needs and convictions of their colleagues, whether in their team or the wider organization. Drawing on attachment theory, I have suggested that we routinely come across leaders whose authenticity and consequent effectiveness is limited by their use of unconsciously defensive leadership styles, which I call defiant and compliant leadership. Defiant leadership arises where a manager denies his/her vulnerability or self-doubt by adopting a dominant and dogmatic style, which tends to evoke resistance and frustration in others. Compliant leadership arises where a manager avoids confrontation by too readily fitting in with the needs of others, and so limiting his/her capacity for assertiveness and creativity.

The psychodynamic approach to coaching provides an opportunity for leaders to examine the relational assumptions that unconsciously underpin their leadership styles. The defiant leader, contained by the coach's attunement and resilience, finds a space to look at feelings that have long been banished from awareness, and so finds an opportunity to re-examine the need to be controlling of others. The compliant leader, invited to connect with hidden frustrations, learns to confront others in a useful way and so gains confidence in his/her ideas and their potential value to others. In this way, psychodynamic coaching can provide a rich learning environment for evoking authenticity and increased effectiveness in executives and leaders.

Team coaching

Just as individuals can adopt defensive strategies for managing feelings, groups can also behave in ways that defend against anxiety. Bion (1961) proposed three defensive strategies, called basic assumptions: fight/flight, dependency, and pairing. For example team members, anxious about how to solve a difficult issue, may become distracted and angry with senior management for putting them in this predicament (fight or flight). By blaming others they spare themselves the emotional challenge of taking responsibility and for integrating mixed feelings they may have about their capacity to solve the issue.

Another way the team may manage their anxiety is by idealizing one of the team members (or sometimes the coach), and then relying on them to resolve the challenge facing the team (dependency). While appropriate followership is useful, dependency means that there is a lack of shared initiative and responsibility within the team, and if the idealized leader is not successful then dependency can turn to fight or flight in relation to the leader. A further defensive strategy, somewhat similar to dependency, is to rely on a pair within the team to solve the team's difficulties (pairing).

The goal in team coaching is to enable the team to manage itself in such a way that it can focus on its primary tasks, drawing usefully on the skills and talents of all of its members, managing differences effectively, operating with appropriate levels of self-disclosure, building creatively on the contributions of others, and effectively managing the boundary with other parts of the organization. By noticing when the team is resorting to defensive strategies, the coach seeks to understand the nature of the anxiety underlying the defence, and from this awareness to decide on an appropriate intervention. This might involve naming the defence in some way, but if the team lacks the resilience to face this observation then the coach might for example encourage the team to work on a simpler, more manageable task in order to reinstate its sense of its effectiveness.

EVALUATING THE PSYCHODYNAMIC APPROACH

In this last section I consider the strengths and limitations of the psychodynamic approach and finish by discussing the contexts in which this approach can be most usefully applied.

Strengths

The psychodynamic approach opens our minds to the possibility that there is substantially more going on below the surface of coaching interaction than can be seen on the surface. Whether it is in the hidden agendas of an organizational sponsor, the defences of a coachee or the diversionary games of a team, the psychodynamic approach provides an unparalleled resource for

investigating and making sense of unconscious processes and their role in shaping, and often limiting, the achievement of goals.

Applied to the arena of coaching, this approach usefully emphasizes the importance of managing boundaries, since it is through an experience of ‘holding’ and safety that coachees can allow their defences to loosen. While coaching is necessarily more flexible than counselling or psychotherapy with regard to the regularity of sessions and the location of meetings, the psychodynamic approach encourages us to recognize that the containment provided by fixed start and end times, a consistent physical environment, and explicit confidentiality, all contribute to an experience of holding, and so make possible a deeper exploration of the coachee’s ways of making meaning.

The coach informed by psychodynamic practice will also have a particular appreciation of the role of restraint and silence in one-to-one work. Viewed as a space for thinking more than doing, reflecting more than solving, coachees come to experience the coach’s restraint as an invitation to go deeper into oneself, to ask the question ‘why’, to sit with the discomfort of not knowing, to tolerate distressing feelings, and to discover the transformative potential of awareness.

The psychodynamic approach does, however, set a challenge to coaches to stretch their own developmental capacity for meaning-making, and undertaking one-to-one work with a psychodynamic practitioner is perhaps one of the most powerful ways of promoting that. The task for the coach is to be able to take a meta-perspective on their own implicit biases and defences, and through this process gain a more expansive awareness of self and others. It is the emotional resilience that comes from such self-awareness and integration that provides coachees with the profound experience of psychological containment, and so enables them to visit parts of themselves that have long been disowned.

Limitations

However, the depth of the psychodynamic approach is not always appropriate in coaching. Quite apart from whether coaches feel qualified to move towards unconscious territory, there are many coachees who neither want nor need this style of work. Coachees are often looking for relatively short engagements to help them think through a particular issue, and so favour approaches that focus on the present and the future, without needing to dig into patterns learned from the past. Where coachees have specific goals or a preference for pragmatic solutions, the psychoanalytic question ‘why do you want that?’ may be less useful than ‘what do you want?’ and ‘how can you get it?’

Furthermore, the psychodynamic approach has the potential to be overly concerned with problems, and so miss the value of focusing on a coachee’s strengths. The positive psychology movement has arisen out of the concern that much of psychological theory has come out of the clinical treatment of mental disturbance, which consequently views people as problems to be solved. Psychoanalytic theory must take some responsibility for this problem-centric bias, and

coaches drawing on the psychodynamic approach need to be cautious about pathologizing coachees. Valuing and building on strengths, appreciating what is working already, and actively celebrating coachee's achievements are important aspects that can put the psychodynamic approach into a more balanced and constructively useful context.

Best use

The psychodynamic approach brings great depth and insight to the work of coaching, and as such is most appropriate for contexts where coachees are interested in exploring the roots of their meaning-making patterns, or where they feel stuck and are prepared to do what it takes to achieve an enduring shift. Leadership, developmental and team coaching, together with coaching supervision, are the areas that lend themselves most to the psychodynamic frame, and in all of these areas I have witnessed the profound effectiveness of the approach. Having said that, I would reiterate that the effectiveness of coaching often derives from the ability of the coach to flex his/her style, to draw on multiple approaches, and so respond usefully to the changing needs of coachees. The psychodynamic approach used within an integrative coaching framework is a potent method for evoking change.

FURTHER READING

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